

■ By Hasan Zaidi in Karachi

For most people in Pakistan, the breaking news flashed early evening on television channels on July 27, was like a bolt from the blue. President Pervez Musharraf was meeting Benazir Bhutto in Abu Dhabi, the self-exiled former prime minister he had vowed to keep out of politics. Bhutto's Pakistan Peoples' Party (PPP) leaders, who had gathered in London for a party meeting to be chaired by her on the same day, seemed equally shocked and clueless. Until the day before, they had been trying to reassure their jittery Opposition colleagues that no deal was in the works with the military Government.

As the news of the secret meeting gained currency, it became increasingly difficult for government sources, and for PPP spokespersons, to deny it. "No such meeting was scheduled between the President and Bhutto, and to the best of my knowledge no meeting has taken place," Musharraf's newly re-appointed spokesman Major-General (retd) Rashid Qureshi told media. But soon Parliamentary Affairs minister Sher Afgan Niazi and Punjab Governor Lt General (retd) Khalid Maqbool confirmed the contact.

The circumstances provided ample evidence that a meeting had taken place. General Musharraf, who was supposed to fly to Saudi Arabia for a highly unusual visit—without the usual Foreign Ministry officials accompanying him but with Inter-Services Intelligence head Lt General Ashfaq Kiyani—had suddenly take a detour to the UAE. Bhutto too had hastily rescheduled her party meeting in London and flown to Dubai with her confidant Rehman Malik. Later she seemed unwilling to be drawn on why she had gone to Dubai.

For Musharraf, it is a stunning turnaround that indicates how weak his position has become in the wake of the judicial and militant crisis of the past few months. That he would need to shore up support from Bhutto, who leads arguably the most popular political party but who he had accused of corruption in his early days, also confirms the pressure he is under from the western powers to reach a compromise with non-religious forces. As he



SUPPING WITH THE ENEMY

In a stunning turnaround that betrays how weak his position is, Musharraf cosies up to Benazir in the run up to the elections

faces opposition from the ruling King's party, the Pakistan Muslim League (PMI-Q), which fears marginalisation should the PPP come into favour, Bhutto's support may help Musharraf stave off political challenges to his ambition of remaining as President beyond October. Bhutto, for her part, would desperately like to see the sword of corruption cases hanging over her head removed. "Bhutto is quite clear that she cannot alone handle the mess of militancy in the tribal areas, the

creeping Talibanisation of the North East Frontier Province and the rebellion in Balochistan," says a PPP insider.

Bhutto, however, risks the ire of her supporters and the opprobrium of her rivals in the Opposition, for striking a deal with a military ruler. Although she has dropped several hints over the past few months that she was not averse to a deal and even confirmed rumours that negotiations were taking place between PPP and Musharraf, she has found it increasingly difficult to justify